MCP

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The Ruler

A Dramatic Monologue

Written by Frank Smith

SCENE I

School Auditorium.

(A line of invisible, chattering students, waiting to get their photos taken. But we only see one:)

JANE.

(JANE (13), unflappable, smiles too big, posing for a picture. She then stops, rolling her eyes.)

JANE: 'Sup. I'm Jane. Ready for a hot topic? I hate pictures. Not just school pictures. Those are dumb. Definitely. But there's something about smiling when you're not, like, you know, in the mood… that just feels very fake and pointless to me. My best friend, Frederica, she felt the same way I did. Whenever we had to take pictures for school, we would have the ugliest expressions on our faces. That sort of made us feel like it wasn't as huge a waste of time as it could be. We were showing how we actually felt – which was that we didn't need to perform for people. And that was our approach to Instagram, too. We made a lot of silly faces that reflected how we actually felt in the moment. I think that's why Frederica had been my best friend for so long. We didn't believe in faking how we were feeling. Even when the truth could be pretty unpleasant.

(Jane walks away, and starts to play a portable video game in the corner.)

JANE: Okay, so to backtrack a little. I first met Frederica on Halloween, when we were both five years old. We were both dressed as the costumes every little girl dresses as at that age: Mario and Luigi, the Super Mario Brothers. Spoiler alert: Frederica and I were both huge gamers. Which wasn't such a common thing for girls in our grade, because boys tried to act like video games were their territory. Which is stupid. It's like saying ice cream is our territory. No, losers, everyone likes video games. Just like everyone likes food. Boys are dumb. So once we came in dressed in matching costumes, Frederica and I became inseparable. We didn't have the exact same interests. I was more into band, because I played the drums. Loudly. Which, of course my parents loved. And she was more into dance, which, inevitably, evolved into cheer as she got older. But we supported each other. She came to my concerts, even though classical music was not really her thing. I went to the games at which she cheered, even though sports are not really my thing. But that's what friends do. They support each other. Through good times, and band.

(Jane loses the game, and groans. She starts up another round.)

JANE: It was really easy to be Frederica's friend in elementary school, because we spent the whole day together. Every class, we sat right next to each other. And then, we would hang out after school. Practically the only moment we weren't together was when we went to sleep at night. We spent about half the time at my place, and half the time at hers. Her parents loved me. Her mom, Helga, especially. Maybe a little too much – she would constantly tell Frederica to be more like me. To study just as much, to work just as hard. It wasn't that Frederica didn't work hard. I guess I just worked a little harder. But she also wore nicer clothes, and put on make-up sooner. So we each had our strengths, I guess. We were a good match. A great match, even.

(Jane cheers, as she advances to the next level. She puts on a determined face, as the game gets significantly harder.)

JANE: When we got to middle school, that's when things changed. Our elementary school, Leland, was combined with three other elementary schools in the area: Johnson, Brown, and Ward. So suddenly, there were four times as many kids in the school. And that meant that Frederica and I didn't have every class together anymore. We shared two out of the eight: Spanish, and Math. Which were two of Frederica's least favorites, so it's not like she was in a great mood when we were in those classes. But still, it was always nice to sit next to her, And be able to exchange notes. But then, the other thing that changed was that Frederica told me, school work was a little tougher for her, especially since she didn't have me in class to whisper things to her, when she didn't understand. So, she needed more time to do her homework. And we weren't spending as many days together after school. My mom told me this was normal. Her mom told me that it was just her way of catching up to me, academically. But I really started to wonder how normal this all was, and if the time apart was going to have an effect on our friendship.

(Jane loses the game, but prevents herself from having too emotional a response. She calmly puts the game aside.)

JANE: It did. There was this girl in our math class, Aly, who was basically the Kim Kardashian of middle school. She was rich and famous, but nobody really knew how. She honestly didn't even say that much. But she walked around with this air about her, like she was so much better than you. And everyone kind of gave into that, and acted like she WAS better than they were. Bow down to Aly, the ruler of 6th Grade. Frederica and I thought that she was incredibly lame, and didn't really act like all the other kids, worshipping the ground she walked on. At least, not at first. But one afternoon, when we were hanging out, for the first time in a while, actually, Frederica said, "You know, Aly's not actually that bad." Kind of out of nowhere. I asked her why she said that. Frederica said, "I don't know, it seems like everyone's hard on her. But I've been talking to her in the hallway and, I don't know, I think she's kind of all right." I didn't really believe what Frederica was saying, but I thought, all right, next time we're in the hallway, I'll give this Aly girl a shot. Nobody likes to be judged without being known.

(Jane goes to play the game again, but decides to give herself a longer break.)

JANE: The next day, between classes, I saw Aly and Frederica giggling together. There was a crowd of people around them, not really part of the conversation, more like passively, witnessing it. So I walked up to these… parasites would be mean, so let's say, onlookers… and tried to join the conversation with Aly and Frederica. "Hey, what are we talking about?" Aly was steely. She didn't say anything to me. Which I figured she'd do. Right as I'm thinking, Frederica is a bad judge of character, I started to say, "Hey Frederica, want to go grab a soda in the cafeteria?" Frederica didn't say anything back. Which was super unlike her. She always had something she wanted to say. "Frederica, did you hear me?" I asked again. Frederica turned to me and said, steely like Aly, "Give us a minute."

(Jane stands and starts pacing, irked out of her mind.)

JANE: I'm floored. I didn't even know what to say to that. Frederica had never talked to me like that, ever. I just turned around, and walked away. And then, I heard Frederica and Aly giggling, which turned into everyone else giggling. I didn't even want to think what they were saying. That afternoon, I was with Frederica in Spanish. Not Aly, thank goodness – she wasn't in that class. Frederica immediately came up to me, and said sorry about how she was acting earlier. "Aly is just weird around new people," she said, "I'll make an effort to talk you up to her, so she doesn't act like that next time." "Okay," I said, 'First of all, I don't really care if Aly likes me or not." "That's a mistake," Frederica said, "She's an important person to know." "Right," I said, "So, I've never cared about that. What worries me is how YOU were talking to me." Frederica smiled and rolled her eyes. "When did you get so sensitive?" she asked. "Sensitive?" I said. "I'm not sensitive. You were being rude." Frederica rubbed my shoulder and said, "Lighten up, Jane. Mario Kart later?" I thought to myself for a moment… before slowly nodding. It had been a while since we had played together. And when she came over that afternoon, it was totally normal, and we had a great time. It was like nothing had changed. Until Frederica's mom walked in. And said she hoped that Frederica was on top of her homework, since she was taking all this time to play video games. Frederica shot back, "Why don't you ask Jane if she's done her homework yet?" Frederica's mom replied, "I don't have to worry about Jane. I always have to worry about you." It was tougher than Frederica's mom usually was, when making comparisons between the two of us. And Frederica looked more upset than ever.

(Jane calms down, and sits again.)

JANE: Over the next few days, every time I tried to talk to Frederica in the hall? She ran off before I had the chance to say anything. And in class, she sat far away from me. In Spanish, it was fine – I was able to throw myself into my work. But in Math, I kept getting distracted by how she and Aly would look at me, point, and giggle. At home, I asked my Mom what she thought was going on. She told me the story about a friend she had in middle school, Clare, who found a new friend, Beverly, and never really talked to my Mom after that. I really didn't want the situation to be like that. My Mom asked if I had tried to talk to Frederica. I said yes, but she wasn't hearing me. My Mom then offered, do you want me to call Frederica's Mom, and see what's up? Maybe she'll tell me something that Frederica won't tell you. I knew this was risky, but I was desperate at this point. I wanted my friend back. I needed her back. I overheard the conversation, just to make sure my Mom wasn't saying anything too embarrassing. But I thought she put it really gently. How I really valued my friendship with Frederica, and how it was wonderful that Frederica was making new friends. Still, I was hoping that, even if we didn't have as much time together as we used to, if Frederica could try to fit me in a little more. Frederica's Mom said that all sounded totally reasonable, and thanked my Mom for calling. I thought that that would do the trick. But all it did was make things worse.

(Jane can't help herself. She dives back into the video game.)

JANE: Now, instead of ignoring me in the halls, Frederica outright made fun of me. Making fun of me for being in band, for my clothes. For playing video games. Things she used to either not mind, or love about me. I never said anything back – what was the point of that? I just retreated. And it wasn't like I was the only girl that she and Aly were making fun of – there was this really

sweet debate student, Micky, who they never had a nice word about, either. I sadly realized that our friendship was over, and I had to move on. But they weren't making it easy – the more I ignored them, the more they tried to make it personal. Saying how nerdy I was, how ugly I was, how friendless I was. I stayed strong there, cried all the way home, and talked to Mom at night. Then, I got ready for the next day of school. But one day, in Math class, something happened that I couldn't just ignore anymore. It was a Geometry assignment, and everyone got passed out these 12-inch rulers. Frederica went out of her way to come over, and steal my ruler. I kept asking her to hand it back, and she kept ignoring me. Finally, I demanded that she give it back, loud enough for the teacher to hear. I didn't go directly through an adult, since I knew that was a trigger of Frederica's, but I needed help getting through in this moment. Frederica grudgingly handed me back the ruler. But she'd written something on it in Sharpie: "Jane has no friends." After all these years, after all these memories, after all my grace – this was what I got from her? I took the ruler, stared Frederica in the eye and slammed it down on her desk, so hard it broke in half. The class gasped. I then grabbed the Sharpie out of Frederica's hand, and scribbled one extra letter on the half of the ruler I still had. Shoved it in her face, so she could see what it said now: "Not friends." For a few days after that, Frederica and Aly made fun of what a little psycho I was. But for some reason, no one seemed to laugh along with them anymore. I think it was the fact that they had tried to make fun of a few too many people, and those people were people like me, and Micky: nice people. Good people. Which Frederica had decided not to be anymore.

(Jane is surprised to see what a hot streak she's on with the game.)

JANE: Frederica's Mom called my Mom, and asked if there was anything to be done. I answered myself: no. Frederica had decided not to be friends with me anymore. And I was choosing to accept her decision. I hung up, confident that I was still nice, that I was still me. And I knew exactly how to prove it – at school, I walked up to Micky in class, and introduced myself. I'd been afraid to do it until now, due to guilt by association. But I knew who my real friends were, and who they weren't. So did Aly – she moved on from Frederica within the week. People were finally seeing how mean she was, and frankly, how badass I was. Frederica came to me in the hall one day, apologizing, saying she didn't know what came over her. She asked if we could be friends anymore. I looked her directly in the eye, and said to her: what it said right there, on the ruler – that still stands.

(Jane wins the game, and cheers triumphantly.)

JANE: Micky is great, though. It's been awesome learning how to debate from her, and she's way better at Mario Kart than Frederica ever was. I've had to really level up my game to be competitive with her. But it's a fun competition – it doesn't feel like I have anything to prove, or anything to feel bad about when I lose. I think that's what real friendship looks like – you better each other. You challenge each other. But you never try to destroy each other. I still have that piece of the ruler that broke. I know that seems weird. But sometimes, in order to know the truth, you have to look directly in the face of a lie. I love my Mom. I love Micky. And I love me. And I sincerely hope Frederica can one day say all those things about herself. I mean that, sincerely.

THE END.